"I'm less of a man (or woman) because of this."

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Where it often comes from

Disability can challenge roles as provider, protector, caregiver, or athlete. Society's images of strength can make us feel less masculine or feminine, especially when injury or illness changes how we work, parent, or relate.

What Scripture teaches

"God created man in His own image… male and female He created them." Your identity as a man or woman in God's image does not depend on strength or ability. "The parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable, and the parts we consider less honorable, we treat with greater honor." "My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness." "When I am weak, then I am strong." Courage, love, faithfulness, and character are the real marks of maturity.

> *"So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them"* (Genesis 1:27).

Also see

> "On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable" (1 Corinthians 12:22).

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> "I praise You, for I am fearfully and wonderfully made. Marvelous are Your works, and I know this very well" (Psalm 139:14).

> "But God chose the foolish things of the world to shame the wise; God chose the weak things of the world to shame the strong" (1 Corinthians 1:27).

Common self-statements

- I cannot be what I should be.
- I have lost my role.
- A real man (or woman) would not need this.
- I am less than before.
- I have failed my family.
- I am not enough.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Believing I am either fully a man or woman or less.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that others will see me as less.
- Emotional reasoning: Feeling diminished and concluding that I am.
- Labeling: Calling myself less.

Challenging questions

- What does manhood or womanhood mean to me, and where did I learn it?
- What qualities of character do I still show?

- How do my loved ones see me?
- What roles can I fulfill differently?
- What does Scripture say about identity and weakness?
- What new role might God give me?

Truth summary

> My identity as a man or woman is a gift from God, not a measure of strength. I can serve my family and others in new ways, with courage and character.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Weakness
- Pride
- God, Creator
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Divorce

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Praise You in This Storm — Casting Crowns featuring Phil Wickham
Suffering and tears do not establish that God is absent or uncaring.

I Am Not Alone — Kari Jobe
God's companionship remains through darkness, weakness, and uncertainty.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

My Plan for Replacing "I'm less of a man (or woman) because of this"

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I'm less of a man (or woman) because of this." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What does manhood or womanhood mean to me, and where did I learn it?
- ☐ What qualities of character do I still show?
- ☐ How do my loved ones see me?
- ☐ What roles can I fulfill differently?
- ☐ What does Scripture say about identity and weakness?
- ☐ What new role might God give me?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am made in God's image.
- ☐ Weaker parts are honored.
- ☐ God's grace is sufficient.
- ☐ In weakness I am strong.
- ☐ My character matters most.
- ☐ I can serve differently.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Genesis 1:27
  "So God created man in His own image; in the image of God He created him; male and female He created them."
- ☐ 1 Corinthians 12:22
  "On the contrary, the parts of the body that seem to be weaker are indispensable."
- ☐ 2 Corinthians 12:9
  "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] New ways to serve: Each week, note one way you served or loved.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Genesis 1:27 becomes: "Sarah can write: "I am made in God's image, and my worth is not my strength.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Weakness" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

These cards support emotional and spiritual care and do not replace medical care. Follow your doctor's advice about treatment and medication, and choose steps that are safe for your body. In an emergency call 911; for thoughts of self-harm call or text 988 (U.S.).

- [ ] Name the roles. Write what you have lost and what remains.
- [ ] Ask your family. Hear how they see you.
- [ ] Find a new role. Mentoring, listening, praying.
- [ ] Read 2 Corinthians 12:9. Rest in His power.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I'm less of a man (or woman) because of this": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	New ways to serve
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I'm less of a man (or woman) because of this.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I feel diminished. Remind me that I am Your image-bearer, and show me how to love and serve in my new circumstances. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.